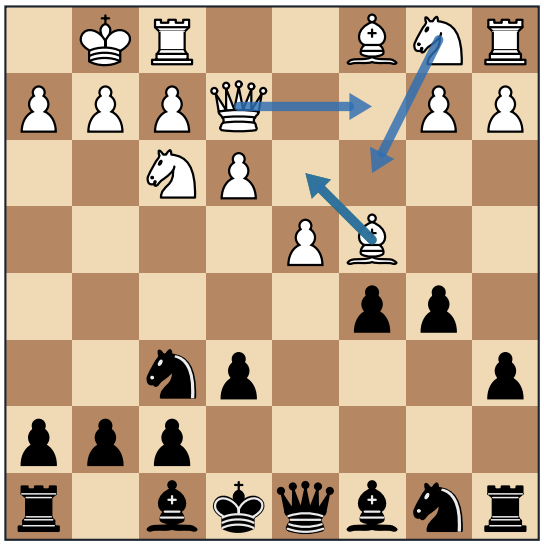
Queen's Gambit Accepted

ECO D20-D29 | 63 named lines | Queen's Gambit / Slav family

In one sentence: The classical 1.d4 opening: White fights for e4 and the center; Black chooses solid structures (QGD, Slav) or active ones (QGA).

Memory pattern: c4 vs d5: White takes the center, Black holds with e6 or c6 and breaks with ...c5.



Main line: 1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5 6.O-O a6 7.Qe2 b5

Key ideas

1. Challenge d5 with c4: if Black takes (QGA), White regains the pawn and gets center.
2. QGD: Black holds d5 with ...e6; the light bishop is the problem piece.
3. Slav: ...c6 keeps the light bishop free for ...Bf5.
4. Exchange Carlsbad: White plays the minority attack b4-b5; Black counters with ...Ne4 and ...f5.
5. Black's freeing moves are ...c5 and ...e5; White's are e4 and Qc2/Bd3 kingside play.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.02** (equal, depth 17). Best: Bd3.

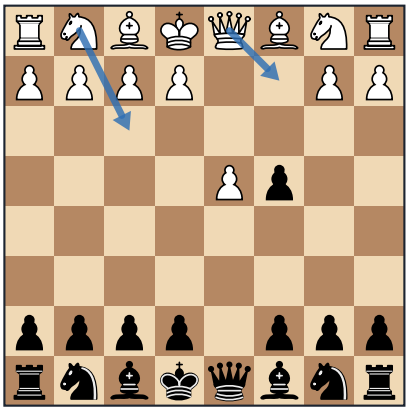
The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	c4/d4 against d5: Carlsbad (c6/e6), Slav chain (c6/d5), QGA (White regains c4), IQP or hanging pawns after exchanges. The minority attack (b4-b5) is White's key plan.
2. Where does my king go?	Both sides castle kingside; the king is rarely attacked early.
3. Best minor pieces?	White: Bg5/Bf4, Nc3/Nf3, Bd3, Rc1. Black: Nbd7, Bb7 or Bf5, Be7, Rc8.
4. Main middlegame plan?	White: minority attack, e4 break or Bd3-Qc2 kingside play. Black: ...c5/...e5 breaks and trading light bishops.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants e4 or a queenside attack; Black wants a pawn break (...c5/...e5) and active bishops.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5 6.O-O a6 7.Qe2 b5

Move	Why it is played
1. d4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... d5	Hold the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. c4	Attack d5. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
2... dxc4	Take the pawn. Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
3. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
3... Nf6	Develops the knight to f6.
4. e3	Support d4. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
4... e6	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
5. Bxc4	Regain the pawn. Develops the bishop to c4.
5... c5	Free the position. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
6. O-O	Castles: the king reaches safety and the rook joins the center.
6... a6	Gains space on the wing.
7. Qe2	Queen move: puts pressure on a target (watch for tempo-gaining attacks).
7... b5	Gains space on the wing.



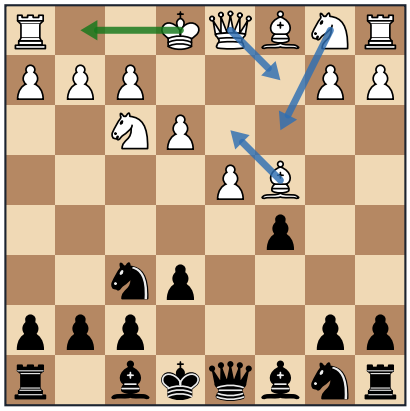
After 1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4



After dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

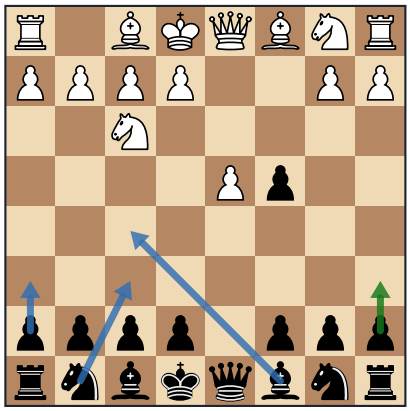


Position after the line

Classical Defense D26 | 15 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5`

Stockfish: **+0.35** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: O-O.
What to look for: c4 (attack d5); Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Alekhine System, Main Line, Steinitz Variation, Rubinstein Variation

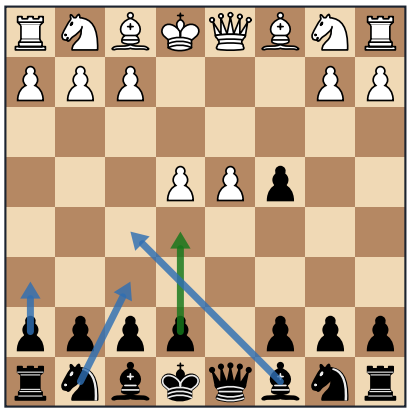


Position after the line

Normal Variation D21 | 8 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3`

Stockfish: **+0.31** (slightly better for White, depth 18). Best next move: a6.
What to look for: d5 (hold the center); e6 (solid); Nf6 (develop)
Sub-variations: Traditional System, .. a6 Sideline

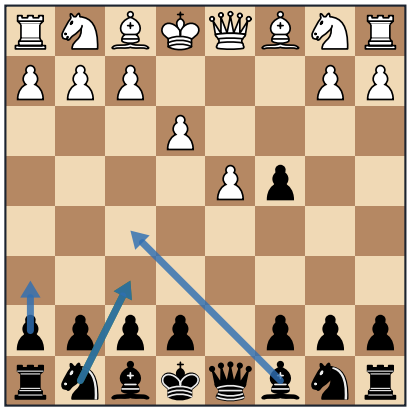


Position after the line

Central Variation D20 | 7 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.e4`

Stockfish: **+0.26** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: e5.
What to look for: d5 (hold the center); e6 (solid); Nf6 (develop)
Sub-variations: McDonnell Defense, Rubinstein Defense, Alekhine System, Greco Variation

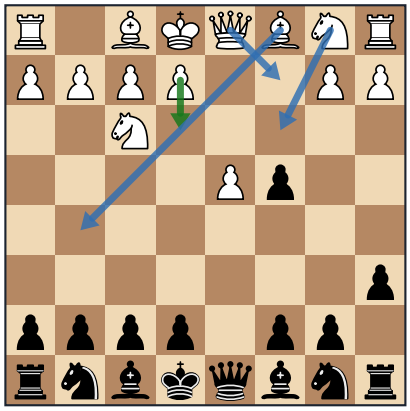


Position after the line

Old Variation D20 | 5 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.e3`

Stockfish: **+0.33** (slightly better for White, depth 19). Best next move: Nf6.
What to look for: d5 (hold the center); e6 (solid); Nf6 (develop)
Sub-variations: Billinger Gambit, Christensen Gambit, Korchnoi Gambit, Novikov Gambit

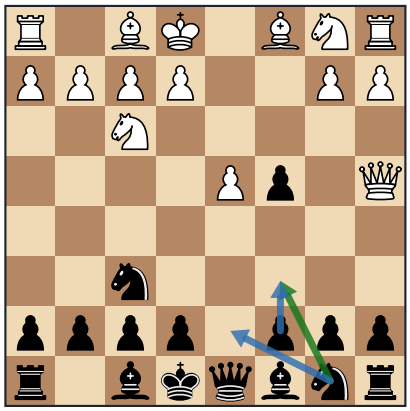


Position after the line

Alekhine Defense D22 | 4 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 a6`

Stockfish: **+0.33** (slightly better for White, depth 21). Best next move: e3.
What to look for: c4 (attack d5); Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Borisenko-Furman Variation, Alatortsev Variation, Haberditz Variation



Position after the line

Mannheim Variation D23 | 3 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Qa4`

Stockfish: **+0.08** (equal, depth 15). Best next move: Nc6.
What to look for: d5 (hold the center); e6 (solid); Nf6 (develop)

Expert and coach view

Capablanca and Karpov played the Queen's Gambit Declined with great success.

What a coach would tell you

Know the three structures: Carlsbad (minority attack), IQP (attack vs blockade) and hanging pawns. Study the plans for each, then choose the QGD, Slav or QGA based on your style.

Why play it

The classical 1.d4 opening: White fights for e4 and the center; Black chooses solid structures (QGD, Slav) or active ones (QGA).

Typical mistakes

• Taking on c4 without a plan to hold the pawn (...b5) or return it.

• Playing Bg5 too early or Nf3 too early without considering ...Ne4 or ...c5.

• Ignoring the minority attack and allowing a permanently weak c6 pawn.

Typical tactics and traps

• Elephant Trap: 1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5 Nbd7 5.cxd5 exd5 6.Nxd5? Nxd5! 7.Bxd8 Bb4+ and Black wins.

• Back-rank tactics when queens trade and the rooks are unconnected.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

QGD endings are usually balanced; Black's solid structure makes winning chances hard for White.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Queen's Gambit Accepted (all lines)** D20
  `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4`
  - **Accelerated Mannheim Variation** D20
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.Qa4`
  - **Central Variation** D20
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.e4`
    - **Alekhine System** D20
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.e4 -> 3...Nf6`
    - **Greco Variation** D20
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.e4 -> 3...b5`
    - **McDonnell Defense** D20
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.e4 -> 3...e5`
      - **Somov Gambit** D20
        `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.e4 e5 -> 4.Bxc4`
    - **Modern Defense** D20
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.e4 -> 3...Nc6`
    - **Rubinstein Defense** D20
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.e4 -> 3...c5`
      - **Yefimov Gambit** D20
        `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.e4 c5 -> 4.d5 b5`
  - **Normal Variation** D21
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.Nf3`
    - **Traditional System** D26
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 -> 3...Nf6 4.e3 e6`
    - **.. a6 Sideline** D26
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 -> 3...Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 a6 6.Nc3 b5`
  - **Old Variation** D20
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.e3`
    - **Billinger Gambit** D20
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.e3 -> 3...e5 4.Bxc4 exd4 5.Qb3 Qe7 6.a3`
    - **Christensen Gambit** D20
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.e3 -> 3...e5 4.Bxc4 exd4 5.Qb3 Qe7 6.Nf3`
    - **Korchnoi Gambit** D20
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.e3 -> 3...e5 4.Bxc4 exd4 5.Qb3 Qe7 6.Kf1`
    - **Novikov Gambit** D20
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.e3 -> 3...e5 4.Bxc4 exd4 5.Qb3 Qe7 6.Nd2`
  - **Saduleto Variation** D20
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.e4`
  - **Alekhine Defense** D22
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.Nf3 a6`
    - **Borisenko-Furman Variation** D21
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 a6 -> 4.e4`
    - **Haberditz Variation** D22
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 a6 -> 4.e3 b5`
    - **Alatortsev Variation** D22
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 a6 -> 4.e3 Bg4 5.Bxc4 e6 6.d5`
  - **Godes Variation** D21
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.Nf3 Nd7`
  - **Gunsberg Defense** D21
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.Nf3 c5`
    - **Prianishenmo Gambit** D24
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 c5 5.d5 e6 6.e4 exd5 7.e5`
  - **Rosenthal Variation** D21
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.Nf3 e6`
  - **Schwartz Defense** D20
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.e4 f5`
  - **Slav Gambit** D21
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.Nf3 b5`

- **Mannheim Variation** D23
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Qa4
- **Showalter Variation** D24
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3
- **Janowski-Larsen Variation** D25
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 Bg4
- **Smyslov Variation** D25
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 g6
- **Winawer Defense** D25
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 Be6
- **Bogoljubow Defense** D24
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 a6 5.e4
- **Classical** D26
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5
  - **Furman Variation** D26
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5 -> 6.Qe2 a6 7.dxc5 Bxc5 8.O-O Nc6 9.e4 b5 10.e5
  - **Flohr Variation** D28
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5 -> 6.O-O a6 7.Qe2 b5 8.Bb3 Nc6 9.Rd1 c4 10.Bc2 Nb4 11.Nc3 Nxc2…
- **Classical Defense** D26
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5
  - **Normal Line** D26
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5 -> 6.O-O
  - **Steinitz Variation** D26
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5 -> 6.O-O
    - **Development Variation** D26
      1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5 6.O-O -> 6...Nc6
    - **Exchange Variation** D26
      1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5 6.O-O -> 6...cxd4
  - **Main Line** D27
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5 -> 6.O-O a6
  - **Alekhine System** D28
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5 -> 6.O-O a6 7.Qe2
    - **Main Line** D29
      1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5 6.O-O a6 7.Qe2 -> 7...b5 8.Bb3 Bb7
    - **Smyslov Variation** D29
      1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5 6.O-O a6 7.Qe2 -> 7...b5 8.Bb3 Bb7 9.Rd1 Nbd7 10.Nc3 Bd6
  - **Rubinstein Variation** D27
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5 -> 6.O-O a6 7.a4
  - **Russian Gambit** D27
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.e3 Nf6 4.Bxc4 e6 5.Nf3 c5 6.O-O a6 7.e4
- **Linares Variation** D20
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.e4 c5 4.d5 Nf6 5.Nc3 b5
- **Furman Variation** D27
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5 6.O-O a6 7.dxc5 Bxc5

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6 5.Bxc4 c5
```

Plan chain

White	c4 -> Nc3 -> Nf3 -> Bg5 -> e3
Black	d5 -> e6 -> Nf6 -> Be7 -> O-O

Three rules to remember

1. c4 vs d5: White takes the center, Black holds with e6 or c6 and breaks with ...c5.

2. White: minority attack, e4 break or Bd3-Qc2 kingside play. Black: ...c5/...e5 breaks and trading light bishops.

3. White wants e4 or a queenside attack; Black wants a pawn break (...c5/...e5) and active bishops.

Pawn structure in one line

c4/d4 against d5: Carlsbad (c6/e6), Slav chain (c6/d5), QGA (White regains c4), IQP or hanging pawns after exchanges. The minority attack (b4-b5) is White's key plan.